

Franciscan friar, denounced the Talmud. He told Pope Gregory IX that the Talmud was offensive and blasphemous and that without it, the Jews would have converted to Christianity long ago.

On March 3, 1240, King Louis IX of France had every copy of the Talmud in the country seized and brought to Paris, where the book was put on trial for blasphemy. Donin prosecuted, and four leading rabbis defended the Talmud. Donin had found passages referring to a Yeshu (Jesus), a false prophet who was the son of a prostitute and had been justly executed. The rabbis answered that this was not Jesus Christ but another man, saying “not every Louis born in France is king.”

The Talmud was condemned and sentenced to be burned. The manuscripts were carried through the streets of Paris in 24 wagonloads to a great bonfire. As a result of this and subsequent public burnings

Yemenite Jews in Jerusalem read and debate the Talmud together. Study of the Talmud was traditionally a male activity to be undertaken once boys had completed a course of Torah study.

elsewhere in Christian Europe, very few complete manuscripts of the Talmud have survived.

Studying the Talmud

The traditional way to study the Talmud was in male-only pairs. Students read a page and argue over its meaning. As the Gemara explains, “when Torah scholars study together, they sharpen one another.” Today, women also explore the book in yeshivas (Jewish schools dedicated to the study of the Talmud, the Torah, and other religious texts). People now read the Talmud online, too, using live streaming or video conferencing, and websites offer to find students a *havruta* (“learning partner”).

In 1923, Meir Shapiro, a Polish rabbi, suggested that Jews around the world should study the Talmud collectively, at the rate of one page a day. This idea was embraced, and tens of thousands of Jews began to read the book together. It took seven and a half years for them to read the Talmud, a cycle first completed in February 1931. The 13th cycle ended in 2020. Today, around 350,000 Jews take part in the collective reading. ■



Rashi

Born in Troyes in northern France in 1040, Rabbi Shlomo Yitzhaki, known as Rashi, was the most influential Talmudic commentator in history. As a young man, he studied in the yeshiva at Worms in Germany. At the age of 25, he returned to Troyes and became a rabbi while also working as a wine maker. He founded a yeshiva of his own 5 years later.

Rashi wrote extensive commentaries on both the Torah and the Babylonian Talmud. His writing was clear and concise, and he analyzed the text phrase by phrase. Although he wrote in Hebrew, he explained the meaning of obscure words in French. Rashi died in 1105 in Troyes.

Ever since the Babylonian Talmud was first printed in the 1520s, every copy of the work has included Rashi's commentary on the inner margin of each page.

Key works

c. 1070–1105 *Commentary on the Torah*

c. 1070–1105 *Commentary on the Talmud*

